



In *Avatars of the Word: From Papyrus to Cyberspace*, James J. O'Donnell, a Professor of Classical Studies and Vice Provost for Information Systems and Computing at the University of Pennsylvania, interprets new communications technologies and their social effects by comparing the present moment to a series of earlier, historically congruent moments of technological transition. The book is informally divided into two parts: the first five chapters present a number of historical snapshots, each of which is subsequently related to technological changes in our own time, and the last four chapters discuss college-level teaching and learning in the context of new communications technologies (p. x). Both parts offer a number of opportunities for reflection. Four brief textual interludes called "hyperlinks" are scattered throughout the book, and allow O'Donnell to pursue ideas generated in the main discussion (i.e., textual instability, nonlinearity, ownership of ideas, and teaching).

O'Donnell's reading of various moments of technological transition, from speech to writing (on papyrus), from writing to the codex book, from manuscript to movable type, attempts to show how the "new" has always depended on the "old" for its identity. In the case of the Internet, for example, O'Donnell says that some of the most radical claims made on behalf of electronic texts are in fact centuries old: notions of textual instability, non-linear reading practices (hypertextuality), and the "virtual" are attributes of other forms of communication as well, most notably handwritten and printed texts.

Because he rejects a view of technological history predicated on a series of ruptures or clean breaks with the past, O'Donnell mobilizes a number of examples in which the past is employed to authorize the present (p. 3). New communications technologies do not simply "supplant" older forms of communication; they "supplement" them (p. ix). For example, in his reading of Plato's *Phaedrus*, O'Donnell calls Socrates' "idealization of one form of communication [i.e., speech over writing] . . . unrealistic" (p. 22) because it fails to recognize not only how Socratic culture relied on multiple media but also how Socrates' conception of speech was already a product of a culture influenced by writing. In the case of the "virtual library" (Ch. 2), O'Donnell traces the fantasy of instantaneous access all the way back to the introduction of the book (p. 32), which in effect turns the dream of a virtual future into an attempt to realize "a future that will be just like the past, only better and faster" (p. 42). In the concluding chapter of his book (Ch. 9), O'Donnell models this view by merging himself as cyberguide—i.e., one who has been "consciously lending a hand to the task of creating for the people and ideas I valued a usable space in the new technological environment" (p. 195)—with Cassiodorus, the fifth century C.E. aristocrat and public servant who

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drew on the past to adjust to the demands of the present (p. 196). In short, O'Donnell resists binary thinking by choosing a third way, a way beyond an "either/or" view. We have already seen how O'Donnell responds to the Socratic binarism of speech/writing. In the case of practice and theory, O'Donnell develops an approach in chapter four called "the pragmatics of the new," in which theory and practice mutually inform each other (p. 88-9).

When an interpretation of the past does not gel satisfactorily with the values of the present (which is typically the case, though not always recognized as such), the past may simply be reinterpreted so that it fits. O'Donnell supports this claim most compellingly in chapter five, which concerns the way that nineteenth century Victorian culture reinterpreted classic texts so that they functioned as "improving models and sage examples of what to avoid" (p. 102). O'Donnell implies that continuity with the past is to be avoided if it means that the past serves to reinforce a narrow, linear view of history. To revise history for the sake of maintaining a set of present values, O'Donnell argues, is to write a master narrative or "legend" in which "our version of western civilization is selective in the extreme" (p. 107).

O'Donnell's solution to the problem of "legend-making" (p. 118) is to find ways to create "a genuinely diverse reading of the present and of the many pasts on which the present draws" (p. 118). In the chapter that follows (Ch. 6), O'Donnell turns to electronic technologies because, insofar as they juxtapose ideas (p. 134), they resist the impetus to construct a single, consistent trajectory of meaning. But despite O'Donnell's rejection of histories based on binary thinking (e.g., past/present, speech/writing, utopian/dystopian [p. 9]), he often contrasts new technology and writing/print in such a way that the former comes to represent a liberation from the constraints of the latter. In addition to providing multiple pathways from the past to the present, electronic texts, according to O'Donnell, may/will: allow users to "revolutionize" (p. 152) and personalize (p. 157) education; provide colleges and universities with the tools to connect the classroom to the outside world (p. 188); bring disciplines and people together in collaborative communities (pp. 150-1); break down traditional barriers (p. 150); foster "a dialogue of conflicting voices" that can produce a "fuller representation of the world" (p. 41); call into question the assumption that "discourse must be fixed to be valid" (p. 41); reinvent publishing as a "performance" that is "interactive, dialogic, and self-correcting" (p. 136); replace "the hegemony of the solemn" with a pragmatics of play (pp. 140-1); and manage "infochaos" (p. 43). Writing and print, on the other hand, are often represented through a series of restrictions on freedom, despite O'Donnell's claim that the codex book (especially annotated, "hyperlinked" editions of the medieval Bible [pp. 56-7]) shares some similarities with the electronic text. O'Donnell's basic claim is that writing/print manages people. For example, in Ancient Greece and Rome, the written word was used "to extend and maintain cultural hegemony" (p. 27). It had the same effect on Latin Christians of the fifth and sixth centuries, who used "the written word with sophistication to organize and control their world" (p. 73). During this period, "books had begun to dominate discourse" (p. 75). The church began to compile a large compendium of rules and regulations, so that "power was [becoming] increasingly centralized and the autonomy of the local community weakened" (36). "Control over texts had brought control over people" (p. 37). In short, O'Donnell's dystopian view of writing/print appears to be in direct opposition to his utopian view of electronic texts.

It is important to note, finally, that O'Donnell focuses much of his attention on the word itself, on production rather than on reception practices. One quickly notices that an "avatar"—what O'Donnell defines as "the form in which some abstract and powerful force takes palpable shape for human perception" (p. xi)—refers mainly to texts, and not to readers or cyberguides (i.e., librarians and professors). O'Donnell explains the instability of electronic texts, for example, in terms of how texts can be preserved when software and hardware requirements change so rapidly (p. 48), and not in terms of (postmodern) changes in reading practices. The same is true of O'Donnell's discussion of nonlinearity, in which books are imbued with agency and readers are nowhere to be found: "If you were a very farsighted text of the second century and you wanted to be read a thousand or more years later, the thing you most wanted was to be copied into a codex format" (p. 52). This observation should not be taken as a criticism of O'Donnell's book, but as an attempt to show what O'Donnell's book not only foregrounds but backgrounds as well.¹ Of course, one could probably not write a book like *Avatars* unless one devoted some space to accompanying changes in reading practices, which is what O'Donnell does, albeit at the level of massive cultural changes taking place in how texts were being received.

Many of the claims in this book are well documented, despite some of the book's shortcomings. The text is accessible and offers a thought-provoking reading experience for a wide range of readers. The reader who is new to theories of electronic communication will find that *Avatars* has a lot to offer, while the reader who is already familiar with many of O'Donnell's claims about electronic communication will appreciate his expertise in contextualizing the present. ♦

¹ The communication triangle, which includes the four basic components of writer, reader, text, and referent, offers a starting place from which to map out O'Donnell's major approaches and assumptions. For a very detailed discussion of the communication triangle, see J. Kinneavy, *A Theory of Discourse*, New York: Norton, 1971.